



Statement by President von der Leyen with Prime Minister of Montenegro Spajić

Podgorica, 1 October 2026

Prime Minister, Dear Milojko,

Thank you for welcoming me to Podgorica. Tomorrow morning, we will inaugurate the new National Coordination Centre. And I am looking forward to it. Because it is truly a milestone towards your EU future. This centre gives your border police the means to monitor, exchange information, and coordinate with agencies in the EU. In other words: we are preparing for Montenegro's borders to become European Union borders. This means not only safer borders for Montenegro. But also greater security for Europe as a whole.

My first message is this: we believe in Montenegro '28 by 28'. And we will support you all the way. This is why I came to Montenegro already three times this past year. Not only to show my personal support but also to commend Montenegro for the impressive work you have been doing.

Montenegro has now provisionally closed more than half of all negotiating chapters. You made important reform progress. Especially on the rule of law over the summer. And this has paved the way for the final stretch. We are working now to close all remaining chapters by the end of this year. This will require continued political stability and broad cross-party support; strong relations with EU Member States; and resilience against attempts to divide and polarise your societies. But the finish line is in sight. And crossing it would send a powerful signal across the Western Balkans: reforms deliver. And EU membership is within reach.

My second message is on the Growth Plan. You know the principle. We bring more European investments. And, as you prepare to join our Union, we open parts of our Single Market to you already now. At the same time, you adopt the key reforms needed to compete and thrive in our respective markets. This is how your economy can gradually converge with the Single Market of the European Union. Now, your success with this Growth Plan is impressive. Montenegro is leading in the region with over 90% of all necessary reforms delivered. You have an allocation of more than €380 million that you can achieve under the Growth Plan. You have received already €89 million. More will come. And I can only commend you for the success of your work with the Growth and the investments of the European Union. I also want to remind you of three examples that have already been delivered. You have joined SEPA, the Single European Payments Area. SEPA has the potential to save Western Balkan companies around €500 million per year – plain and simply because the transaction fees go down. They have already fallen by more than 90% for Montenegro. And transfers of up to €200 are completely free. boons it is a big advantage for the companies. We are also reducing roaming charges. Montenegrins will be able to call home at no additional costs when they are in the EU. In Europe we know from experience that it is a great way of bringing people closer together. Finally, I remember our investment conference in Luštica last year which was a great success with over 14 deals signed between European Union and Western Balkan companies. And I know that the second edition that you will have in due time will be quite a success as well.

My last message is the following. You are getting ready. And so are we. Because enlargement is a two-way process. Candidate countries must be ready to join, without any question. And the EU must also be ready to welcome candidate countries that join the European Union. That is why next week we will present our pre-enlargement policy reviews. We will look at our institutions, our policies, and our budget. All that has to be done to be ready to welcome a new Member State and to make sure our Union is ready to become larger in all the policies and institutions that we have.

As always, accession will remain merit-based. But merit-based does not mean slow. Especially in today's geopolitical reality. That is why, in a second step, we will soon set out roadmaps for our most

advanced candidates. Montenegro, of course, is among them. These roadmaps will turn the path to membership into concrete steps – what remains to be done, who has to do what and by when, and what progress should follow. Finally, with Montenegro we are one step ahead. The work is now advancing to prepare your accession treaty. In June, we proposed Montenegro's accession financial package. The aim is to prepare the financial transition from candidate country to Member State. This ensures continuity from day one of membership. And it prepares Montenegro to participate fully in the priorities that you are setting out for the next seven-year long-term budget.

Prime Minister, this is the last stretch after years of efforts. If Montenegro keeps delivering the way it does, together we will be able to fulfil the European aspirations of the people of Montenegro. Reward all the work you have done since years. I am convinced you can do it. And what is absolutely for sure: you can count on us.

Thank you.

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